Dancing with A Stranger

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Dancing with A Stranger

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Summary

Shadow Weaver is out for the night, for absolutely no reason at all, alone on February 13th. Until someone crashes into her and she suddenly knows exactly why she's there.

Or

"Look what you made me do, I'm with somebody new; uh, baby, baby, I'm dancing with a stranger" ~ Castaspella

Notes

Hi! Welcome!

Today I bring you… this kinda anti-valentine's fic!

Obviously inspired by the song Dancing with A Stranger, that's a given XD

Anyways… Enjoy!!

See the end of the work for more notes

The night was just starting.

The relatively-old woman had no idea what she was doing there at the club among so many youngsters, but there she was.

Low lights, loud music, lasers, and smoke… it all looked mysterious and oneiric.

Seriously, *what* was she doing there!?

She'd soon find out…

Right after finishing her glass of wine, which had earned her a few odd looks, the woman left her stool and was immediately rammed by someone.

—I'm so sorry…

—Rushing somewhere?— the old woman scoffed, before catching sight of the young face looking back at her. —Are you alright?

It was a noticeably young woman.

And she was crying.

—I'm fine— she assured her, brushing away her tears. —I didn't mean to bump into you. What- Um, I'm Esmeralda, but most know me as Castaspella— she decided to introduce herself.

—Beatrix. But I'm known by different names by my students depending on how good or bad they are— she replied, smirking.

—A teacher?

—Why so surprised?

—Didn't expect to find a teacher somewhere like this.

—And I didn't expect to find a researcher here either.

—Oh, please, I…

—*You* are the main source of information for defense magic classes, you know?

—Oh…

—Why did you tell me your pseudonym if you didn't expect me to recognize you?

—It's a habit… I'm so sorry— Castaspella apologized.

—No need to be sorry.

—So… you teach… and your students call you by different names?

—For the ones with real potential, my best students, I'm known as "Light Spinner". For the rest… well, I'm instead "Shadow Weaver".

With a gasp, the young woman immediately said —The infamous Shadow Weaver!?

—There's no such thing as "bad fame"— she laughed. —But it's interesting that you have heard of me too…

—Of course! You taught my brother long ago… I just had no idea that his Light Spinner was also everyone else's Shadow Weaver— Castaspella laughed.

She had a nice laugh.

—You must have a talented brother, huh?

—Yes… I'm nothing like him, though…— she sighed. —Would that mean I'd know you as "Shadow Weaver"?

—Only if that's what you'd call me— the woman replied, smirking again.

—Wait, so… the students call you one or the other name according to how you treat them?

—Exactly.

—Mean…

—Yes, that's an accurate one-word description of me as Shadow Weaver— she smirked.

—And, say… who did you come here as, tonight?

—Hmm… Great question. Well, taking everything into account, tonight I'm just Beatrix.

—Alright… and would Beatrix want to dance?

—Lucky for you, I do— she sighed.

They spent a while dancing together to a couple of songs, keeping each other close in the middle of the multitude of youngsters dancing, and for the most part, Castaspella laughed and smiled with the woman.

For the most part…

It wasn't that long before she realized how happy she was, and her expression fell.

—I- So-sorry… I'm…

—What's wrong?— the old woman asked, moving her face closer to hear her better.

—I'm having fun, but…

—But?

—I shouldn’t be here…

—Why?

—I just shouldn’t— she insisted, attempting to leave.

—Says who?— Shadow Weaver inquired, defiant as she held her by the wrist to keep her from leaving.

—Don't do this to me…

—Do what?— she insisted, pulling her closer again and stopping a hair’s breadth away from her.

—I…— she stammered, before closing the distance and kissing her.

The old woman kissed her back, holding her close, and relishing the feeling.

She realized she had been craving this for a while now, and it surprised her.

Being touch-starved wasn’t new, but finding someone who could actually satiate that starvation was very unexpected.

There was passion in that kiss. Longing. And relief…

Hunger, need, *thirst*…

And then, just as fast as she initiated it, Castaspella cut the kiss short and stepped away.

—Wait. Wait!

—No, no… I should leave— she denied, shaking her head.

—Stay a moment, let’s talk— Shadow Weaver insisted. —There’s someone, isn’t that right?

—Yes…

—I sense a “but”.

—*But* he’s being an idiot— she explained. —Look, I… wasn’t going to go out. Yet I didn’t want to be alone tonight, and I really needed to get him off my mind.

—I see… Let’s take a seat at the bar and you can explain it to me a bit more.

—Really?

—Sure. It sounds like you need someone to hear you out— the old woman nodded.

—Why?

—Today is February the thirtieth… Do I need to explain more?

—Hah… and I haven’t even told you why I was crying when I arrived…

—Then let’s sit and you can explain it all to me, alright?

Nodding several times, Castaspella agreed and followed Shadow Weaver to the furthest corner of the bar.

After asking for a couple of drinks, the old woman gestured at her to start talking.

—Alright, so… Yeah, tomorrow is Valentine's, but… that's not the worst part— she began, staring into her drink. —Today was… our *anniversary*— she revealed. Looking at Shadow Weaver now, she scoffed as she explained —He's at the bachelor's party of one of his friends, instead of- Ugh…

—Perhaps he had to choose between that and spending the day with you; peer pressure can be hard to ignore…

—No, no, you don't understand— Castaspella denied, shaking her head. —He was the organizer. He *chose today* to hold it, and forgot it was our anniversary!

—Oh, I see…— she nodded, pensive. Both took a sip at the same time, and then she spoke — Listen. It seems to me that you really care for this relationship. So, in my outsider opinion, you should probably sit and speak to him. See what he wants and whether that aligns with what you want.

—You… think so?

—It's not fair for you to be suffering like this, but perhaps he didn't mean to hurt you…

—I doubt it, but… yeah, I need to speak to him— Castaspella nodded. —Thank you— she smiled.

—No need to thank me— Shadow Weaver denied.

With a deep sigh, the young woman finished her drink and stood up.

—Oh, before I forget… Um, would you mind giving me your number? Whatever happens… I'd like to see you again— she admitted, with a small smile.

—It'd be my pleasure.

—Thank you.

And so, after exchanging phones, the researcher left and the teacher was left alone to finish her drink.

The following day would be an interesting Valentine's Day for sure…

Around ten in the morning, Shadow Weaver's phone began ringing.

And kept on ringing…

She wasn't really going to pick up, but curiosity got the best of her, so she finally did.

—Who is this?

—Esme- Castaspella— the researcher replied, at the other end of the line, voice broken.

—Es, what happened?

—I'm sorry, I know it's early… Can we meet?

—Sure, o-of course. The… bar, where we met yesterday, it has some great breakfasts, if you want…

—Yes, that would be good.

—Alright. See you there— Shadow Weaver nodded, giving her a moment before hanging up.

That didn't sound good.

Actually, that sounded terrible.

The woman sure hoped Castaspella had gotten some sleep…

Thinking about it, she wondered whether the researcher lived with this boyfriend or not.

She sure hoped she didn't…

It wasn't long before the women were sitting at the bar, in a booth, waiting for their breakfast to arrive.

—So… I guess I should start explaining myself. I did call you pretty early— Castaspella began. —Did I wake you up?

—Maybe…

—Sorry.

—Don't apologize. It sounded to me like you were crying. What happened?

—That… *jerk*.

—You talked.

—Well, I certainly tried. He was more like… shoving me away.

—So it didn't go well.

—At all— the young woman scoffed. —He was so… so disdainful of the importance of our anniversary! Of how important it was for me! So you can imagine what he thinks of today…

—I'm sorry to say I dislike this particular day quite a lot…

—And what would you do if you had a partner?

—Why do you think I don't?

—Do you?— Castaspella asked back, raising a brow. —With all due respect, so I thought…

—Fine, I wouldn't be a jerk about it if my partner liked today- Well, I *would* be a tiny bit bitchy about it, but certainly wouldn't overdo it. And much less an anniversary— Shadow Weaver had to admit.

—Well, he was more than a jerk about it. I- Ugh, I am so, *so* glad we never moved in together…— she huffed. —Anyways… The thing is… After how pleasant the time with you was last night, I… well, I realized I hadn't felt that comfortable and happy with him in… a long, *long* time— she admitted, looking away. —So I decided to end our relationship.

Silence.

Shadow Weaver stared, shocked, and blinked a few times.

—You dumped him on Valentine's?

—It was past midnight, so yes. And he didn't give two shits about it— Castaspella confirmed, unamused. —You see: he didn't really care about our relationship, but it took me too long to realize. If I hadn't- Well, if I hadn't met you, I wouldn't have realized yet…

—A-and what do you plan to do now?

—Well, I was… wondering if…you'd be willing to see me again?

—Oh, *of course* you would jump into the arms of the first stranger you meet!— a mocking voice interrupted, before Shadow Weaver could reply. —Even one who looks like… that. You're *so* afraid to be alone, aren't you?

The woman didn't really need confirmation, but Castaspella's expression served as such.

Frowning, baring her teeth, and hands tightly balled into fists…

This was the infamous boyfriend.

—It's *not* that! I am *not* afraid of…

—Uh, sure…— he interrupted. —Happy Valentine's, Baby Girl— he sardonically said, grabbing his coffee and promptly leaving.

—Do not *fucking* call me that!

The researcher was fuming, and with all due reason. But he only laughed and walked out.

Shadow Weaver was unsure of what to do, but upon noticing how everyone in the bar was staring, she immediately barked —Mind your own business, will you!?

—He just… *had to*— Castaspella seethed, looking down, holding her head with both hands.

She didn't seem to notice as a hesitant waitress brought them their breakfast, until her stomach rumbled and she was forced to acknowledge the food in front of her.

—Es, are you… alright?

—Of course not! But… I…

—Eat, go ahead— Shadow Weaver encouraged her.

—Yeah, I should— she sniffed, brushing away a tear. —And sorry about that… comment on your appearance…

It was, certainly, an awful Valentine's Day for the researcher.

And this old woman, of all the people in the world, was probably the worst option to fix that…

They both ate in silence for a while, Castaspella too upset to talk, and Shadow Weaver a bit uncomfortable but mostly racking her brain to find some way of cheering her up.

And then she remembered…

The question.

Well, she could perhaps make an effort this time.

She'd hate most of it, but… perhaps she'd be in for a surprise too…

—So, you made a question earlier. And I would like to answer.

—Ye-yes? You don't have to. It's…

—What about visiting the fair two blocks away? Take your head off of things?— she interrupted.

—That'd be- Ye-yes, I'd like that— Castaspella nodded, with a soft expression.

—Then allow me to pay and we'll go.

—Split the bill— she requested.

—Are you sure?

—Yeah, of course! I should be paying fully, I invited- kind of. Anyways, I'd rather we split the bill.

—Fine by me— Shadow Weaver chuckled.

A while later, just as agreed, the women were walking through the local funfair.

—This place is huge! I'm impressed!

—You never visit the fair when it's here?

—Not really— Castaspella admitted. —Always wanted to, but… I didn't want to come alone, and *Mister Fun* always refused…

—Well, you're here now. Enjoy— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—I already am— she smiled.

—Hmm… Tell you what. I'll get you something, anything. What would you want?— the old woman asked, as they kept walking through game stalls.

—Anything?— she asked back, looking around. —Oh, I know! Look at that cutie!

—A capybara toy?

Shadow Weaver observed, with her head tilted, as the young researcher approached a booth with fluffy toys on display.

—You know? Where it's native from, they call it a "Carpincho". I think that's a better name— Castaspella laughed.

—Alright. Call it whatever. That's what you want?

—Yes!— she nodded, with a bright expression.

—Alright, let's get you the… *carpincho*.

It took Shadow Weaver plenty of attempts, and they had to make a break for lunch, but eventually, the old woman won Castaspella the tiny toy she wanted.

It was a small capybara toy with wristlets to attach the toy to your arm.

And Castaspella was delighted.

Well, that smile was certainly worth cheating with some magic, after all.

She was kind of running out of money…

In any case, the researcher now had her toy and was happy.

Very happy.

Her eyes almost sparkled, she kept petting the toy and giggled like a kid.

It made Shadow Weaver feel *something*.

And she didn't like it…

The… endearment.

No, no.

She had to get out of there.

—It's such a cute thing! Cute carpincho!

—Well, it's… also getting a bit late, so I guess I should call you a cab, no?— the old woman asked, trying to hide her anxiety.

—I- No, well, I mean… I suppose… It is a bit late, yes…— Castaspella admitted, dejected.

As she started to caress the capybara again, in some sort of self-comforting way, Shadow Weaver felt yet another shift inside her.

Another kind of fear, another kind of panic.

—Es, listen. Could you do me a favour?

—Tell me.

—Would you mind going to the academy next week? To give a little open class to my students…

—You… want me to impart a class?

—Or do a presentation. Whatever you prefer.

—I'd like that— Castaspella finally smiled. —But on one condition.

—Which is?

—That we go to have lunch together afterwards— she requested.

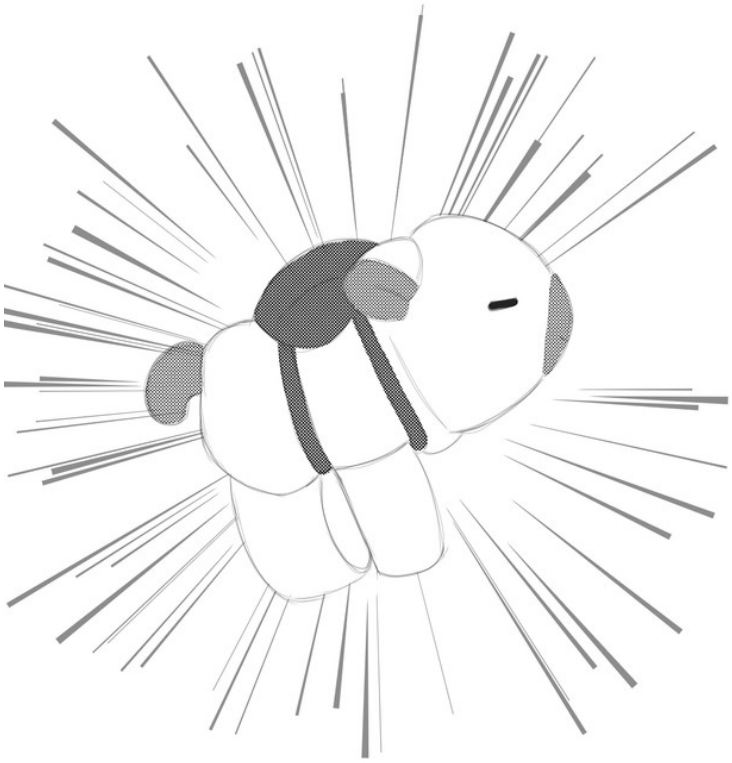
—Much obliged— Shadow Weaver faintly smiled.

End Notes

Ok! Don't have much to say, but I have something to show you!!

I present to you: The carpincho toy!!







And, uh, yeah, we call it "carpincho" here, they are truly cute, and after getting that toy last month, I *had* to include it!!
Isn't it just the most adorable little thing!?

Anyways XD
Thank you very much for reading!!!
And for those who like it, Happy Valentines! :D

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